RSS Digest
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1. My obituary for programming
Source: Simon Willison’s Weblog | Published: 2026-10-19T23:58:25+00:00
Link: https://simonwillison.net/2026/Oct/19/my-obituary-for-programming/
My obituary for programming Jeremy Scheff poignantly captures the key loss caused by coding agents for career programmers who enjoyed the puzzle of developing code: Programming turned into one of the greatest jobs you could imagine. You got paid to work on tricky little logic puzzles. The trickier the puzzle, the more you got paid. But even pretty simple puzzles were worth a lot of money because regular people just couldn’t do it! No, they needed us. They would give us a problem and we would solve it the way we wanted. We set the strategy, we made the timeline, we defined what was and was not possible. If you’re a programmer who thrives on building working systems and doesn’t care too deeply about the problems solved along the way, LLMs are the gift that keeps on giving. If directly solving those problems was a big part of your enjoyment, the loss is very real. Via lobste.rs Tags: programming , careers , ai , generative-ai , llms , coding-agents , deep-blue

2. Laypeople support technical fields for technology, not art
Source: seangoedecke.com RSS feed | Published: Tue, 20 Oct 2026 00:00:00 GMT
Link: https://seangoedecke.com/laypeople-support-technical-fields-for-technology-not-art/
Some people think that LLMs should not be used in technical fields like programming or mathematics , because those fields are actually art. True or not, this kind of argument is not going to be persuasive to the general population. The argument goes something 1 like this: It doesn?t matter how effective LLMs are at technical fields like programming or mathematics, because one of the essential values of those fields is that they?re art . While it looks to laypeople like these fields exist to solve practical problems, what they?re actually for is to produce works of beauty, or to express something distinctively human, or to spend time contemplating the infinite . Simply solving the problems misses the point in the same way that building an infinite poem generator would miss the point of poetry. I agree that programming or mathematics can be beautiful. I remember being mildly awestruck at learning epsilon-delta proofs , and I have written a lot about the kind of software I think is elegant. Since there?s no clear definition of art or of aesthetics in general, it?s plausible to me that almost everything could have an artistic dimension to it. All of this is compelling to software engi...

3. Feds Suspect Ransom Negotiator Ran ShinyHunters Extortion Site
Source: Krebs on Security | Published: Mon, 19 Oct 2026 13:48:56 +0000
Link: https://krebsonsecurity.com/2026/10/feds-suspect-ransom-negotiator-ran-shinyhunters-extortion-site/
U.S. federal investigators pursuing the ShinyHunters hacking group that recently stole highly sensitive data from the FBI have identified executives at two different ransomware negotiation firms who maintained unusually close relations with the extortion group, KrebsOnSecurity has learned. Sources close to the investigation say one of the executives in the United States even helped ShinyHunters operate a website that pressured victims into paying a ransom.

4. Why do we need ud2 when int 6 is right there?
Source: The Old New Thing | Published: Mon, 19 Oct 2026 14:00:00 +0000
Link: https://devblogs.microsoft.com/oldnewthing/20261019-00/?p=112781/
An interrupt is not a fault. The post Why do we need ud2 when int 6 is right there? appeared first on The Old New Thing .

5. Refactoring factorials
Source: John D. Cook | Published: Mon, 19 Oct 2026 14:55:22 +0000
Link: https://www.johndcook.com/blog/2026/10/19/refactoring-factorials/

Splitting N! into N factors is trivial. It?s defined as the product of N integers, the integers 1 through N. Can you still split N! into N factors if you put a minimum size requirement on the factors? You can?t split 3! into three factors unless one of the factors is 1, but you can split 4! into factors ? 2: 4! [?] The post Refactoring factorials first appeared on John D. Cook .

6. A frivolous problem with a deeper lesson
Source: John D. Cook | Published: Mon, 19 Oct 2026 12:00:43 +0000
Link: https://www.johndcook.com/blog/2026/10/19/regex-backtracking/
About 14% of English words can be spelled by stringing together chemical symbols. For example, sarcasm can be written S Ar Ca Sm using the symbols for sulfur, argon, calcium, and samarium. How would you write a program to determine whether a word can be written by stringing together chemical element abbreviations ignoring case? Obviously [?] The post A frivolous problem with a deeper lesson first appeared on John D. Cook .

7. Pluralistic: The technopolitics of ad-tech (19 Oct 2026)
Source: Pluralistic: Daily links from Cory Doctorow | Published: Mon, 19 Oct 2026 07:08:31 +0000
Link: https://pluralistic.net/2026/10/19/spying-v-context/
Today’s links The technopolitics of ad-tech: Spying is good for tech, context is good for publishers. Hey look at this: Delights to delectate. Object permanence: PNH x Mike Ford; Singapore v Far East Economic Review; Publishing v bestsellers; Architecture v security; Vista v everyone; Free Bieber; Belarus sells the sugar bowls; OCCUPY GEORGE; Grey type sucks; Spinal Tap v studio math; Terry Pratchett x $10t coin; Boy Scouts x copyright maximialism; Canadian Tories x DRM; Herman Cain’s 9-9-9 plan; ACLu v secret laws; Fined for suing the cops who shot you; Chicago PD steals millions for cop toys; Turing’s Law; Copyleft v Vizio; Trump’s killswitch. Upcoming appearances: Vancouver, Victoria, Ottawa, Vienna, Kilkenny, Oxford, Sheffield, Virtual, Oxford, Montreal. Recent appearances: Where I’ve been. Latest books: You keep readin’ em, I’ll keep writin’ ’em. Upcoming books: Like I said, I’ll keep writin’ ’em. Colophon: All the rest. The technopolitics of ad-tech (permalink) "Technopolitics" are the politics embedded in technology. The Ur-text of technopolitics is "Do Artifacts Have Politics?" by the rock critic turned scholar Langdon Winner: https://faculty.cc.gatech.edu/~beki/cs4001/Win...

8. Barack Obama on the Trump Administration?s Intimidation Campaign Against Congresswoman Ilhan Omar
Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-10-20T01:12:26Z
Link: https://x.com/BarackObama/status/2111819687524774170
Barack Obama, in a 430-word essay: It is a basic principle of American democracy that the government can?t selectively target individuals simply because of their political beliefs or what they say. But that?s exactly what the Trump Administration is doing to Congresswoman Ilhan Omar of Minnesota. [...] The fact that any president, or any administration, is willing to engage in such transparent efforts to intimidate someone should outrage all Americans, regardless of how they feel about Congresswoman Omar?s political views. Because if this becomes the new normal, there?s no reason to believe it will stop with her ? or that future presidents, in either party, won?t do the same. Thoughtful, sharp, and eloquent as ever. But Obama posted this essay on X, which, I have been told in the past week, shows that he in fact is a Nazi sympathizer , a fascist , a pedophile , and unconcerned about racism . As surprised as I was to learn those things about myself, I?m equally surprised to learn them about President Obama, whom I heretofore considered a thoughtful statesman and moral compass. Either that, or, Threads, Bluesky, and Mastodon have relegated themselves into irrelevance by allowing the...

9. From the DF Archive: Should a CEO Be a Nerd About Their Company?s Products?
Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-10-19T22:36:15Z
Link: https://daringfireball.net/linked/2022/10/11/ceos-as-nerds

Back in 2022, I quoted from an interesting post by Ben Schlappig at One Mile at a Time, where he wrote : I?ve had the opportunity to interact with quite a few senior airline executives over the years, and I find that their knowledge about competitors is typically one extreme or the other: Some airline executives literally couldn?t tell you the first thing about their competitors, and have no knowledge of their passenger experience, fleet, etc. Some airline executives know literally everything about their competitors, down to being able to tell you how many seats competitors have on specific planes I find there are very few executives who are just kind of in the middle, as it?s pretty polarizing. Either they know virtually everything about competitors, or nearly nothing. Without naming any names, I?ll say that generally speaking there?s a high correlation between airlines that have a great passenger experience, and airlines that have executives that keep very close tabs on the competition. And I wrote: If the CEO?s primary perspective on the company is via spreadsheets ? if it?s all just P&L to them ? that company is not going to excel at quality. Or if they do excel at quality, th...

10. Apple Event, in Los Angeles, Next Week: ?Pro and Tell?
Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-10-19T22:27:21Z
Link: https://x.com/gregjoz/status/2112212372182249831
Greg Joswiak, on X: Can?t wait to pro and tell next week. Juli Clover, MacRumors : Rumors suggest Apple is planning to debut the new MacBook Pro with an OLED touchscreen display, an M6 entry-level MacBook Pro, an M6 iMac, an iPad mini with an OLED display. ?

11. No More Icons In Every Menu By Default
Source: Jim Nielsen?s Blog | Published: Mon, 19 Oct 2026 19:00:00 GMT
Link: https://blog.jim-nielsen.com/2026/icons-in-every-menu/
Have you heard the good news? I bemoaned the approach of putting an icon in every menu item by default which shipped with macOS Tahoe ? but now it?s gone in Golden Gate! John Gruber wrote about this reversion back in June , including the fact that Apple?s new Human Interface Guidelines specifically call out Tahoe?s approach to menus as an example of what not to do on macOS. As the old saying goes, it takes a big man corporation to admit when they?re wrong. As I mentioned in my original post , one of the arguments I had in my quiver against this practice was ?Apple doesn?t do it?. But once Apple started putting icons in all their menus in Tahoe, I lost a persuasive point in my argument. But now, I think I have an argument that?s even stronger than before! It?s no longer: ?Apple doesn?t put icons in their menus.? It?s: ?Apple tried putting icons in all their menus, and even they went back on it!? They designed it, shipped it, lived with it for a year, then publicly changed their guidance on it. To me, that?s a lot more persuasive than simply saying, ?Apple doesn?t do this.? Choosing not to do something you?ve never done is one thing. Choosing not to do something you?ve done is exper...

12. The Lean Educator Conference
Source: Steve Blank | Published: Mon, 19 Oct 2026 13:00:20 +0000
Link: https://steveblank.com/2026/10/19/the-lean-educator-conference/
Announcing a Lean Educators Conference. Teaching Lean in the Age of AI. November 18-19th at K&S Ranch, California. When AI hit our spring Lean Launchpad for Deep Tech class, our teaching team was unprepared for the impact it made on the class. What I didn?t realize was that other Lean educators (Hacking for Defense, NSF [?]

13. Weekly Update 526: Building HIBP AI/SI First
Source: Troy Hunt | Published: Mon, 19 Oct 2026 06:47:58 GMT
Link: https://www.troyhunt.com/weekly-update-526/
I have this sense that we’ve passed the point where "vibe coding" is a derogatory term. I have no empirical evidence for this; it’s more a feeling that those weaponising the term have now accepted the inevitability and are just getting with the program.